

India POST: India's Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology

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Abstract

This paper argues that India should establish a dedicated parliamentary science office, modeled on the UK Parliament's Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology (POST), to strengthen legislative scrutiny in an era of rapid technological and scientific change. It examines the limitations of India's current institutional arrangements, where executive bodies such as NITI Aayog provide valuable policy expertise but do not fully substitute for an independent, parliamentary-level scientific advisory function. Drawing on comparative institutional analysis and scholarship in Science and Technology Studies, the paper shows that a legislative science office would give Parliament a non-partisan, evidence-based capacity to assess complex issues in areas such as artificial intelligence, digital governance, climate adaptation, and public health. Such an office would enhance democratic accountability by helping legislators evaluate technical claims, challenge executive assumptions, and make more informed decisions. The paper concludes that an Indian POST should be understood not as a duplicate of executive advisory institutions, but as a necessary complement that strengthens Parliament's ability to deliberate independently and govern scientifically.

Introduction

The quality of legislation depends not only on democratic procedure but also on the depth and rigor of parliamentary deliberation. As scientific and technological developments accelerate, legislatures face growing pressure to assess complex evidence, emerging risks, and contested policy pathways (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; OECD 2019). In domains such as artificial intelligence, digital governance, climate adaptation, and public health, policy decisions increasingly hinge on technical judgments that are not easily accessible to legislators without specialized support. To keep pace with rapid innovation and make technical knowledge directly available to India’s Parliament, the legislature could benefit from establishing its own POST, modeled on the parliamentary office in the United Kingdom (UK Parliament, n.d.).

India’s Parliament does maintain general research and support structures, including the Lok Sabha Secretariat and related parliamentary services. However, these bodies primarily provide broad administrative and documentary assistance rather than a dedicated, anticipatory, and independent scientific advisory function. This distinction matters. A legislature that depends only on executive or administrative sources may struggle to independently evaluate technical claims, especially when those claims are shaped by policy priorities of the government of the day. Drawing on Sheila Jasanoff’s (1990; 2004) framework of science advisors in policymaking, legislatures often face a structural weakness when they lack internal capacity to test technical evidence and challenge assumptions without relying on executive expertise. A permanent parliamentary science office would help ensure that parliamentary discourse remains grounded in evidence-based analysis, reduces the influence of unverified claims, and strengthens democratic accountability in public administration (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999).

This issue is especially important in India because Parliament must scrutinize legislation in contexts where executive bodies, while technically competent, are not institutionally neutral in the same way as a legislative office. NITI Aayog plays an important role in strategic planning and policy coordination, but it is a government think tank, positioned within the executive branch and accountable to the government rather than to Parliament itself. As

a result, its knowledge production is shaped by executive priorities and political timing. A parliamentary office, by contrast, would serve elected representatives across party lines, including opposition members and backbenchers, thereby enhancing the independence and breadth of legislative scrutiny. The need for such an office is not merely administrative; it is institutional and democratic (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004)

Methodology

This study employs a conceptual institutional analysis, drawing on comparative documentation from the UK Parliament’s POST and India’s NITI Aayog, alongside established scholarship in Science and Technology Studies (STS) (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; NITI Aayog, n.d.; UK Parliament, n.d.). It evaluates the structural similarities and differences between executive advisory institutions and legislative scientific support bodies, with attention to issues such as independence, mandate, and parliamentary function. The paper also examines how a legislative science office could fit within India’s parliamentary framework, including possible institutional placements under the Lok Sabha/Rajya Sabha Secretariats or as a direct support mechanism for Department-Related Standing Committees, such as the Standing Committee on Science and Technology.

Given its focus on institutional design and comparative governance rather than direct empirical measurement, this paper does not generate primary field data. Instead, it offers a comparative and normative framework for legislative reform, grounded in the institutional logic of legislative independence and evidence-based scrutiny. This approach is appropriate for assessing the viability of a parliamentary science office in India, particularly where the central question is whether existing structures are institutionally capable of offering independent scientific advice to Parliament (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999).

Discussion and Conclusion

Scientific advice for legislatures is distinct from executive policy advice because its primary purpose is to support legislative deliberation, scrutiny, and public accountability rather than to directly implement government policy (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; Weingart 1999). In this sense, a parliamentary science office is not simply another expert unit within the state apparatus. It is a mechanism for strengthening Parliament’s ability to exercise independent judgment, challenge executive assumptions, and make technically informed decisions in the public interest. This distinction is especially significant in contemporary India, where legislative issues increasingly involve complex technical evidence, cross-sectoral impact, and long-term societal consequences (OECD 2019; IPCC 2023).

While NITI Aayog plays a vital role in executive strategic planning, its institutional position as a government think tank is fundamentally different from a parliamentary office serving elected representatives directly (NITI Aayog, n.d.). NITI Aayog can offer expertise to the government, but it does not resolve the structural problem of Parliament lacking an internal, independent scientific capacity. This distinction is crucial in fields such as artificial intelligence, climate adaptation, energy transition, and digital regulation, where legislative decisions must balance scientific uncertainty, public accountability, and political judgment (OECD 2019; IPCC 2023).

Ultimately, the establishment of an Indian POST should not be viewed as redundant with executive bodies such as NITI Aayog. Rather, it should be understood as a necessary institutional complement: one body advises the government, while the other strengthens the capacity of Parliament to scrutinize, question, and deliberate independently. Such an office would help ensure that India’s legislative process remains not only democratic but also scientifically informed and institutionally resilient. Further research should assess the direct impact of the UK Parliament’s POST on legislative efficiency and policy outcomes to provide stronger empirical grounding for reform. For India, creating a parliamentary science office remains a vital institutional step toward strengthening the scientific foundation of democratic lawmaking (Jasanoff 1990; Jasanoff 2004; UK Parliament, n.d.; Weingart 1999).

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